

# Marie Curie

The woman who figured out **RADIOACTIVITY**, was the first woman to win a Nobel Prize, and was also the first person to win two

## All about me

- **BORN:** 1867
- **DIED:** 1934
- **NATIONALITY:** Polish
- **FACTOID:** My oldest daughter, Irene, also won the Nobel Prize in Chemistry.
- **IN A NUTSHELL:** Born in Warsaw, Poland, I studied physics and mathematics in Paris, France. There I met Pierre Curie, who became my husband.



## Radioactivity

The Curies worked together to investigate **radioactivity**. Marie proved that the atoms of radioactive elements fire off **HIGH-ENERGY** particles, which we call radiation. This proved that atoms were more than just solid balls. They also discovered two new radioactive elements, called **polonium** and **radium**, and later realized that radiation could be used to treat diseases such as cancer.

*By the way...  
unaware of the dangers,  
I died of aplastic anemia  
(a blood disorder) due  
to radiation exposure  
from my own research.*



## The X-factor

Knowing that radioactive elements emit X-rays, Marie improved the **X-ray machines** used in hospitals. She created a new machine that was small enough to fit into ambulances and, during the **FIRST WORLD WAR**, her mobile X-ray units were used to diagnose soldiers who were too badly wounded to travel to a hospital.

*During the war, Curie herself drove X-ray equipped ambulances to the front lines.*

